Method Selection Form

Fillable PDF. Click a blue box to type; tick the small squares. Save with **File › Save** and attach the saved PDF to your assignment. Works best in the free Adobe Acrobat Reader; macOS Preview and web browsers also work. If an answer does not fit its box, continue it on an extra page. Source: `Step_01_Epistemological_Alignment_and_Method_Selection/method_selection_form.md` (rebuild with `tools/make_fillable_pdfs.py`).

Use this form to document your methodological decisions using the exact four-layer progression defined in the Socio-Ecological Systems (SES) Method-Selection Decision Tree.

Project Details

- **Project Title:**
- **Primary Research Question:**
- **Lead Researcher:**

Layer 1: Epistemological Paradigm

What is your philosophical worldview for this project? (Select one)

- ☐ **Positivism:** Reality is objective and measurable.
- ☐ **Constructivism:** Reality is socially constructed.
- ☐ **Pragmatism:** What works is what matters.
- ☐ **Subjectivism:** Reality is shaped by individual perspective.
- ☐ **Critical Theory:** Knowledge must expose power and oppression.

Justification for this paradigm: *(Explain why this worldview best aligns with your research question)*

Layer 2: Research Objective

Based on your paradigm, what is your primary goal? (Select one)

- ☐ **Objective: Generalize:** Find universal truths and mechanisms (Positivism).
- ☐ **Objective: Understand:** Capture the lived experience (Constructivism).
- ☐ **Objective: Solve:** Address a practical problem (Pragmatism).
- ☐ **Objective: Interpret:** Analyze signs and meaning (Subjectivism).
- ☐ **Objective: Change/Emancipate:** Challenge the status quo (Critical Theory).

Justification for this objective: *(Explain what you hope to achieve or provide for the community/literature)*

Layer 3: Main Methods & Tools

Which SES-specific social science methods are you selecting based on your objective?

Positivist Methods:

- ☐ Longitudinal surveys, experiments, and structured psychometric scales
- ☐ Implicit Association Tests (IATs) to measure unconscious bias

Constructivist Methods:

- ☐ Ethnography and participant observation (Deep cultural immersion)
- ☐ Focus group discussions (Group sense-making)

Pragmatist Methods:

- [ ] Participatory mapping and community-based methods (Community-driven data)
- [ ] Mixed-methods sequential or concurrent designs (Convergent evidence)

Subjectivist Methods:

- [ ] Narrative analysis and photo-elicitation (Semiotic & narrative data)
- [ ] IATs for implicit landscape values (Perception of landscape)

Critical Theory Methods:

- [ ] Participatory action research (Action-oriented inquiry)
- [ ] Critical discourse analysis (Policy & discourse)

Methodological Rationale: *(Document why this specific tool(s) is most appropriate, noting any constraints like time, funding, or population literacy)*

Layer 4: Ecological Linkage (The SE Bridge)

How is your social data linked to the biophysical ecosystem? (Select at least one)

- [ ] **GIS / Remote-Sensing Overlay** (Spatial overlay of social & biophysical data)
- [ ] **Bio-Indicators & Field Transects** (Ecological health ground-truthing, surveys, point counts)
- [ ] **Policy Critique & Institutional Mapping** (Governance & regulatory analysis)

Integration Strategy: *(Briefly detail how you will merge the social and ecological datasets analytically)*

Final Methodological Summary

(Write a short 2-3 sentence summary uniting all four layers. Example: "Operating from a Constructivist paradigm to understand lived experience, we will use Ethnography and FGDs. We will bridge these qualitative insights with the ecosystem via Policy Critique to understand how local governance impacts natural resources.")

[Your summary here]